# WHAT IS LANGUAGE AND THE ENGLISH LANGUAGE

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## WHAT IS LANGUAGE?

Language is a uniquely human, systematic, arbitrary, and symbolic means of communication.

Language is one of **the most remarkable and complex features** of **human beings**. It is **the primary medium** through which we communicate **ideas, express emotions, and interact with our social environment**. Understanding what language is forms the foundation for studying any particular language, including English.

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- ★ **the primary medium**
- ★ **ideas, express emotions, and interact with our social environment**.

## Definitions of Language by Different Scholars

Over the years, numerous scholars and linguists have attempted to define language. Each definition highlights different aspects of this complex phenomenon.

### 1. Aristotle (Ancient Greek Philosopher)

According to Aristotle, **"Speech is the representation of the experience of the mind."** Aristotle viewed language as a speech sound produced by human beings to express their ideas, emotions, thoughts, desires, and feelings. This definition emphasizes language as a tool for representing mental experiences.

### 2. Ferdinand de Saussure (Swiss Linguist, 1857-1913)

Saussure defined language as **"an arbitrary system of signs constituted of the signifier and signified."** In his view:

- ★ Language is a system based on no inherent logic or reason
- ★ The system covers both objects and expressions used for objects

- ★ Objects and expressions are arbitrarily linked (there is no natural connection between a word and what it represents)
- ★ Expressions include sounds and graphemes (written symbols) used by humans for generating speech and writing

Saussure's definition laid the foundation for modern structural linguistics and highlighted the arbitrary nature of linguistic signs.

**3. Edward Sapir (American Linguist and Anthropologist, 1884-1939)**

According to Sapir, language is **"a purely human and non-instinctive method of communicating ideas, emotions, and desires through a system of voluntarily produced sounds."**

This definition emphasizes several key points.

- ★ Language is exclusively human
- ★ It is non-instinctive (learned, not innate)
- ★ It serves as a method of communication
- ★ It uses voluntarily produced sounds

Sapir's definition highlights the unique human capacity for language and its purposeful nature.

**4. Leonard Bloomfield (American Linguist, 1887-1949)**

Bloomfield stated that **"The totality of the utterances that can be made in a speech community is the language of that speech community."**

Bloomfield's definition;

- Focuses on actual utterances produced by community members
- Emphasizes the social and communal nature of language
- Concentrates on form rather than meaning
- Initially overlooked writing, focusing primarily on spoken language

**5. Bernard Bloch and George L. Trager (American Linguists)**

According to Bloch and Trager, **"A language is a system of arbitrary vocal sounds through which a social group cooperates."**

Their definition emphasizes the following points.

- ★ Language as an arbitrary system
- ★ The use of vocal sounds
- ★ Language as a means of communication
- ★ The social and cooperative function of language

**6. Noam Chomsky (American Linguist, born 1928)**

Chomsky views language as **"the inherent capability of native speakers to understand and form grammatical sentences."** He also describes language as **"a unique phenomenon, without significant analogue in the animal world."**

- ★ Viewing language as an innate biological endowment
- ★ Proposing the concept of Universal Grammar
- ★ Emphasizing the creative aspect of language (the ability to produce and understand infinite sentences)
- ★ Considering language as a mental/cognitive system

**7. Patanjali (Ancient Indian Linguist)**

Patanjali stated that **"Language is a human expression produced by different speech organs of human beings."** Through speech organs, humans produce several expressions that are converted into language.

**8. Encyclopedia Britannica**

According to Encyclopedia Britannica, **"Language is a system of conventional or written symbols through which human beings, as members of social groups and participants in their culture, communicate."**

This definition emphasizes:

- ★ Language as a system of symbols (both spoken and written)
- ★ The conventional nature of language
- ★ Language as a tool for communication within social and cultural contexts

Language is a uniquely human, systematic, arbitrary, and symbolic means of communication. While scholars define it differently - emphasizing various aspects such as its mental representation (Chomsky), its social function (Bloomfield), its

arbitrary nature (Saussure), or its human specificity (Sapir) - all agree that language is fundamental to human civilization and culture.

## Common Features in Definitions of Language

Despite their differences, most definitions of language share certain common features.

1. **Human-specific**: Language is unique to human beings
2. **Systematic**: Language operates according to rules and patterns
3. **Arbitrary**: The relationship between words and their meanings is not natural but conventional
4. **Communication**: Language serves primarily as a means of communication
5. **Social**: Language exists within communities and cultures
6. **Symbolic**: Language uses symbols (sounds, gestures, or written marks) to represent meaning
7. **Creative/Productive**: Language allows us to create and understand infinite new sentences

## Essential Characteristics of Language

Based on the various definitions and linguistic research, we can identify the following essential characteristics of language:

1. **Arbitrariness**: There is no natural or logical connection between a linguistic sign and its meaning (there is no reason why "dog" should refer to a canine animal)

2. **Duality/Double Articulation**: Language operates at two levels - sounds (phonemes) and meanings (morphemes)

3. **Displacement**: Language allows us to talk about things that are not present in time or space

4. **Productivity/Creativity**: Speakers can create and understand sentences they have never encountered before

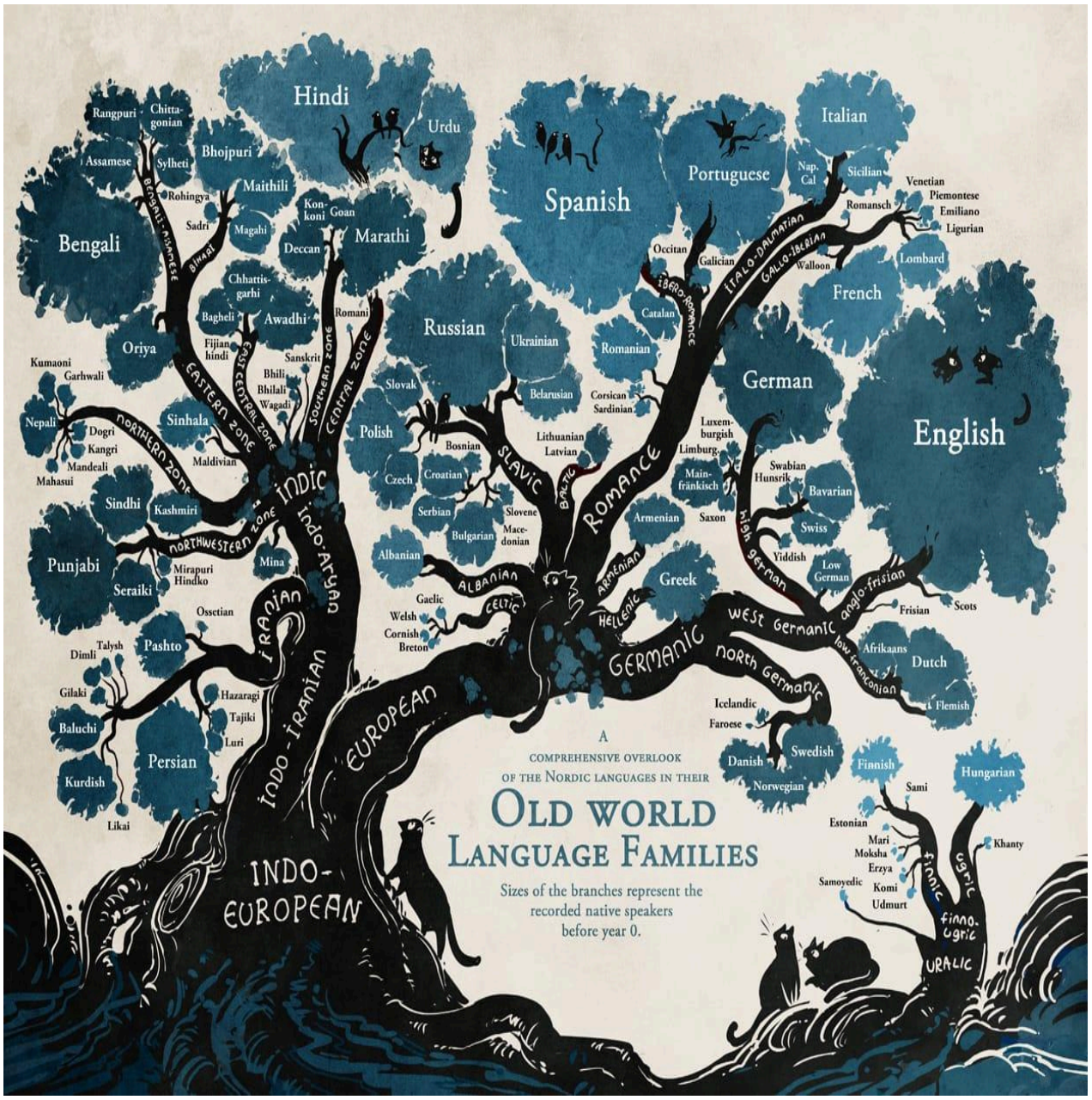
5. **Cultural Transmission**: Language is passed from one generation to another through learning, not biological inheritance

6. **Discreteness**: Language uses distinct units (phonemes, morphemes, words) that combine to create meaning

7. **Systematicity**: Language is rule-governed and structured

## THE ENGLISH LANGUAGE

### Origin of the English Language



➔ **Indo-European Language Family**

To understand the origin of English, we must first understand its place in the broader family of languages. English belongs to the **Indo-European language family**, which is one of the largest and most widespread language families in the world.

➔ **The Indo-European Family includes**:

- ★ **Germanic Branch**: English, German, Dutch, Danish, Swedish, Norwegian, Icelandic
- ★ **Romance/Italic Branch**: Spanish, French, Italian, Portuguese, Romanian (derived from Latin)
- ★ **Slavic Branch**: Russian, Polish, Czech, Serbian, Ukrainian, Bulgarian
- ★ **Indo-Iranian Branch**: Hindi, Bengali, Persian, Punjabi, Kurdish
- ★ **Celtic Branch**: Irish, Welsh, Breton, Scottish Gaelic
- ★ **Greek Branch**: Ancient and Modern Greek
- ★ **Baltic Branch**: Lithuanian, Latvian
- ★ **Albanian Branch**: Albanian
- ★ **Armenian Branch**: Armenian

The Indo-European languages are believed to have descended from a common ancestor called **Proto-Indo-European**, spoken around 4000-3400 BCE in the region that is now southern Russia and Ukraine (the Pontic-Caspian steppe region).

## English within the Germanic Branch

English belongs specifically to the **West Germanic** sub-branch of the Germanic languages. The Germanic branch has three main divisions:

1. **West Germanic**: English, German, Dutch, Frisian, Afrikaans, Yiddish
2. **North Germanic**: Danish, Swedish, Norwegian, Icelandic, Faroese
3. **East Germanic**: Gothic (now extinct)

English is most closely related to Frisian (spoken in parts of the Netherlands and Germany), with German and Dutch being the next closest relatives.

➔ **The Anglo-Saxon Settlement (5th-6th Centuries CE)**

The English language began to take shape when Germanic tribes migrated to Britain in the mid-5th century CE (around 450 CE). According to the

Venerable Bede, an 8th-century historian, three main Germanic tribes invaded Britain.

1. **The Angles** - from southern Denmark
2. **The Saxons** - from northwestern Germany
3. **The Jutes** - from northern Denmark (Jutland)

These tribes spoke dialects of West Germanic languages that were mutually intelligible. When they settled in Britain, their languages merged and evolved into what we now call **Old English** or **Anglo-Saxon**.

The Anglo-Saxons displaced the indigenous **Celtic-speaking Britons**, who were pushed into the western and northern parts of Britain (Cornwall, Wales, Scotland). The Celtic languages and Latin (used during Roman Britain, 43-410 CE) had very little influence on Old English, with English borrowing only a small number of Celtic words.

## History and Expansion of English

The history of the English language is typically divided into three main periods.

### Period 1: Old English (c. 450-1150 CE)

#### Characteristics of Old English

- ★ Very different from Modern English - a modern English speaker would not understand Old English
- ★ Highly inflected (like German), with complex grammar including cases, genders, and verb conjugations
- ★ Rich in consonants and had different pronunciation patterns
- ★ Vocabulary was primarily Germanic, with some Latin borrowings from Christian missionaries
- ★ Four main dialects: **Northumbrian**, **Mercian**, **Kentish**, and **West Saxon**

#### Major Influences on Old English

1. **Latin Influence** (7th century onwards)

    - When the Anglo-Saxons converted to Christianity (beginning with St. Augustine's mission in 597 CE), Latin became the language of the Church
    - Many religious terms were borrowed: "altar," "angel," "bishop," "monk," "mass"

- Other Latin words entered English: "wine," "butter," "cheese," "pepper," "school"

2. **Old Norse Influence** (8th-11th centuries):

    - Viking invasions and settlements (beginning around 793 CE) brought Old Norse speakers into contact with Old English speakers
    - The Vikings established the **Danelaw** (areas under Viking control in northern and eastern England)
    - Old Norse and Old English were similar enough for mutual intelligibility
    - Many common English words come from Old Norse: "sky," "egg," "knife," "leg," "window," "they," "them," "their"

**The End of Old English**: Old English came to an end with the **Norman Conquest of 1066**, when William the Conqueror, Duke of Normandy (France), defeated King Harold at the Battle of Hastings.

## Period 2: Middle English (1150-1500 CE)

**The Norman Conquest and Its Impact**:

★ After 1066, **Norman French** (a dialect of Old French) became the language of the ruling class, the court, and the law
★ English was relegated (put down) to the language of the common people
★ This created a sociolinguistic divide: French for the elite, English for the masses/ majority.

**Characteristics of Middle English**:

★ Massive influx (flow) of French and Latin vocabulary (especially in areas of government, law, military, fashion, food, and culture)
★ Simplification of grammar (loss of many inflections)
★ Development of a more fixed word order (Subject-Verb-Object)
★ English gradually re-emerged as the dominant language by the 14th century

**French Loanwords in English**:

★ Government/Law: "government," "parliament," "judge," "jury," "crime," "prison"
★ Military: "army," "navy," "soldier," "captain," "battle," "enemy"
★ Food: "beef," "pork," "mutton," "salmon" (note: animals have English names - cow, pig, sheep - but their meat has French names)
★ Culture: "art," "music," "dance," "fashion," "beauty"

- ★ Approximately **30-40% of Modern English vocabulary** comes from French and Latin combined, making English a uniquely hybrid Germanic-Romance language.
- ★ **Important Middle English Text**: Geoffrey Chaucer's *The Canterbury Tales* (late 14th century) is the most famous work in Middle English. Although difficult for modern readers, it is much more recognizable than Old English.
- ★ **The Transition to Modern English**: The transition from Middle English to Early Modern English occurred around 1500 CE and was marked by several important developments:
    - ➔ The **Great Vowel Shift** (1400-1700): a major change in pronunciation
    - ➔ The invention of the **printing press** by William Caxton in England (1476), which helped standardize spelling and grammar
    - ➔ The **English Renaissance** and increased contact with other cultures

**Period 3: Modern English (1500-Present)**

**Early Modern English (1500-1700)**:

- ★ The language of William Shakespeare, the King James Bible, and the colonization of North America
- ★ Continued expansion of vocabulary through:
    - ○ The Renaissance (borrowing from Latin and Greek)
    - ○ Exploration and trade (borrowing from many world languages)
    - ○ Scientific revolution (creation of technical vocabulary)

**Late Modern English (1700-Present)**:

- ★ Further expansion of vocabulary due to:
    - ○ The Industrial Revolution (technical and scientific terms)
    - ○ The British Empire (borrowing from languages worldwide)
    - ○ Technological innovations (computer, internet, digital terminology)

## The Expansion of English Around the World

English's transformation from a language spoken by a few million people on a small island to a global lingua franca is one of the most remarkable stories in linguistic history.

English spread globally through:

- British colonial expansion (16th-20th centuries)
- American cultural and economic dominance (20th-21st centuries)

- The internet and globalization (1990s-present)

## Phase 1: British Colonial Expansion (16th-20th Centuries)

**The British Empire** was the primary vehicle for spreading English around the world. At its height in the early 20th century, the British Empire:

★ Covered approximately **one-quarter of the Earth's land area**
★ Governed over **400 million people** (about a quarter of the world's population)
★ Had territories on every inhabited continent

**Mechanisms of English Expansion**.

1. **Colonization and Settlement**:
    - **North America** (17th-18th centuries): British settlers established colonies that became the United States and Canada
    - **Caribbean** (17th-19th centuries): British colonies including Jamaica, Barbados, Trinidad and Tobago
    - **Australia and New Zealand** (18th-19th centuries): British settlement led to English becoming the dominant language
    - **South Africa** (19th-20th centuries): British colonization introduced English alongside Afrikaans
2. **Trade and Commerce**:
    - British trading companies (e.g., the East India Company) established English as the language of business
    - English became essential for participating in international trade
    - Port cities and trading hubs adopted English
3. **Education and Administration**:
    - British colonial administrators made English the language of government
    - English-medium schools were established throughout the empire
    - **Lord Macaulay's Minute on Indian Education (1835)** formalized English education in India, aiming to create "a class of persons, Indian in blood and colour, but English in taste, in opinions, in morals, and in intellect"
    - English proficiency became associated with social mobility and access to power

4. **Missionary Work**:
    - Christian missionaries used English to spread religion
    - Missionaries established schools and taught English alongside Christianity

**Geographic Spread**:

- ★ **Asia**: India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Singapore, Malaysia, Hong Kong, Myanmar (Burma)
- ★ **Africa**: Nigeria, Ghana, Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania, South Africa, Zimbabwe, Zambia
- ★ **Caribbean**: Jamaica, Barbados, Trinidad and Tobago, Bahamas
- ★ **Pacific**: Australia, New Zealand, Fiji, Papua New Guinea
- ★ **Americas**: Canada (alongside French), Belize, Guyana

**Kachru's Three Circles Model**:

Linguist Braj Kachru developed a model to describe the spread of English:

1. **Inner Circle**: Countries where English is the primary native language (UK, USA, Canada, Australia, New Zealand, Ireland)

2. **Outer Circle**: Former British colonies where English serves as an official or important second language (India, Nigeria, Philippines, Singapore, Pakistan, Ghana, Kenya)

3. **Expanding Circle**: Countries where English is learned as a foreign language for international communication (China, Japan, Russia, Brazil, most of Europe)

## Phase 2: American Influence (20th-21st Centuries)

After World War II, the United States emerged as a global superpower, further reinforcing English's global dominance:

1. **Economic Power**:
    - The U.S. became the world's largest economy
    - American multinational corporations spread English globally
    - English became the primary language of international business

2. **Cultural Influence**:
    - Hollywood films and American television programs
    - American music (jazz, rock, hip-hop)
    - American brands and consumer culture
3. **Technological Innovation**:
    - The internet was developed primarily in the United States
    - Early programming languages used English
    - Major tech companies (Microsoft, Apple, Google, Facebook) are American
    - English dominates online content
4. **Scientific and Academic Dominance**:
    - English became the primary language of scientific publication
    - Top universities use English as the medium of instruction
    - International academic conferences are conducted in English

**Phase 3: Globalization and the Internet Age (1990s-Present)**

1. **The Internet**:
    - Initially, over 80% of internet content was in English
    - Programming languages use English keywords
    - Social media platforms originated in English-speaking countries
2. **International Organizations**:
    - English is an official language of the United Nations, European Union, NATO, WHO, and most international bodies
    - International aviation and maritime communication use English
3. **Business and Trade**:
    - English is the lingua franca of international business
    - Most multinational corporations use English as their working language

## Recent Developments and Current Position

Today, English occupies an unprecedented position as;

- The most widely spoken language globally (1.5 billion speakers)

- The primary language of international business, science, technology, and diplomacy
- A language increasingly shaped by its non-native speakers
- A language facing both opportunities and challenges in the 21st century

## English as a Global Lingua Franca

**Current Statistics** (as of 2024-2025):

★ **Total speakers**: Approximately 1.5 billion people worldwide
★ **Native speakers**: Approximately 360-400 million
★ **Second language speakers**: Over 1 billion
★ **Official language**: In 88 countries and territories
★ **Most widely taught**: Foreign language globally

**English's Unique Position**: Unlike historical lingua francas (Latin, Greek, Arabic), English is:

★ Truly global, spoken on every continent
★ Used primarily by non-native speakers
★ Constantly evolving through its diverse speakers
★ Not tied to a single political power

### Recent Developments

1. **World Englishes and New Varieties**:
    - English is no longer owned by native speakers
    - New varieties are emerging: Indian English, Nigerian English, Singaporean English (Singlish), Filipino English
    - These varieties have their own grammar, vocabulary, and pronunciation patterns
    - The concept of "Standard English" is being challenged
2. **English as a Lingua Franca (ELF)**:
    - Most English communication now occurs between non-native speakers
    - ELF prioritizes successful communication over adherence to native-speaker norms

    - Features: flexibility in pronunciation, simplified grammar, incorporation of words from other languages
    - Challenge to traditional English teaching methods
3. **Technology and English**:

    - AI and machine translation are changing language learning
    - However, English remains dominant in technology
    - New English words are constantly created for technological innovations: "selfie," "blog," "tweet," "google" (as a verb), "emoji"
4. **Challenges to English Dominance**:

    - Rise of Mandarin Chinese (due to China's economic growth)
    - Growing importance of Spanish (500+ million speakers)
    - Increased use of machine translation
    - Debates about linguistic imperialism and cultural dominance

**<u>Current Position in Different Domains</u>**

1. **Business and Economics**

    - Primary language of international trade
    - Language of most multinational corporations
    - Required for many high-level positions globally

2. **Science and Academia**

    - Over 95% of scientific papers are published in English
    - English is the medium of instruction in many universities worldwide
    - International conferences are typically conducted in English

3. **Diplomacy and International Relations**

    - One of six official UN languages (English, French, Spanish, Russian, Arabic, Chinese)
    - Working language of most international organizations
    - Language of international treaties and agreements

4. **Entertainment and Media**

    - Hollywood films dominate global cinema
    - English-language music is popular worldwide
    - International news agencies primarily use English

5. **Technology and the Internet**

    - Despite the growth of other languages online, English remains dominant
    - Most programming, software development, and technical documentation is in English
    - Major social media platforms originated in English

6. **Aviation and Maritime**

    - Official language of international aviation (mandated by ICAO)
    - International maritime communication uses English

**<u>Debates and Controversies</u>**

1. **Linguistic Imperialism**:

    - Critics argue that English dominance threatens linguistic diversity
    - Many indigenous languages are endangered or extinct
    - Concerns about cultural homogenization
2. **Access and Inequality**:

    - English proficiency is linked to economic opportunity
    - This creates disadvantages for non-English speakers
    - Access to English education is unequal globally
3. **Ownership of English**:

    - Who owns English? Native speakers or the global community?
    - Should English teaching focus on native-speaker models or global communication?
    - The rise of ELF challenges traditional norms
4. **Future of English**:

- Will English remain dominant?
- Could another language (Mandarin, Spanish) challenge it?
- How will technology (AI translation) affect English's role?

**KEY TERMS TO REMEMBER**

1. **Language**: A systematic, arbitrary, symbolic means of human communication
2. **Indo-European**: The language family to which English belongs
3. **Germanic Branch**: The sub-family of Indo-European languages that includes English
4. **Old English**: The earliest form of English (450-1150 CE)
5. **Middle English**: The form of English influenced by Norman French (1150-1500 CE)
6. **Modern English**: The current form of English (1500-present)
7. **Lingua Franca**: A language used for communication between people who speak different native languages
8. **Kachru's Circles**: A model describing English speakers (Inner, Outer, Expanding circles)
9. **World Englishes**: The various forms of English spoken globally
10. **English as a Lingua Franca (ELF)**: English used for international communication between non-native speakers

**QUESTIONS**

1. How do the various scholarly definitions of language complement each other? What aspects of language does each emphasize?

2. Why did English, rather than other languages, become the global lingua franca? What historical factors were most important?

3. How has the English language changed through its three major periods (Old, Middle, Modern)?

4. What are the advantages and disadvantages of having English as a global language?

5. How might the role of English change in the future? Will it remain the world's lingua franca?

6. What is the significance of "World Englishes" and English as a Lingua Franca (ELF) for English language learning and teaching?

7. How has colonialism shaped the current global distribution of the English language?

8. Should English belong to native speakers or to all who use it? Explain your position.

**RECOMMENDED READINGS FOR FURTHER STUDY**


1. Crystal, David. *The Cambridge Encyclopedia of the English Language*
2. Baugh, Albert C. and Thomas Cable. *A History of the English Language*
3. Kachru, Braj B. *The Alchemy of English: The Spread, Functions, and Models of Non-Native Englishes*
4. Jenkins, Jennifer. *World Englishes: A Resource Book for Students*
5. Graddol, David. *English Next: Why Global English May Mean the End of 'English as a Foreign Language'*